THE FREELANCER'S KIT

Paid On Time.

Stop chasing. Start a routine. Get paid for the work you already did, without the awkward emails.

Inside: the 3 rules · payment terms you can copy · the invoice checklist · the 6-step reminder ladder · every script, email and WhatsApp · what to say when clients make excuses · how to use the app and tracker

START HERE

Why you get paid late (it's not just the client)

Surveys of freelancers keep finding the same thing: weeks every year lost to chasing invoices, and most freelancers feel uncomfortable doing it, so they put it off. Then they wait until they're angry, send a sharp email, and the relationship sours.

Most late payments aren't malicious. The invoice had no clear due date, went to the wrong person, or nobody reminded the client until it was already a problem. That's good news: **it's a process problem, and process is fixable.**

01
Agree before you start
Terms in writing: deposit, due date, late fee. No terms, no leverage.

02
Make paying easy
A real date, the right person, and how to pay, all on one page.

03
Remind on a schedule
Not when you're annoyed. The ladder does the emotional work for you.

The 2-minute daily habit: open Paid On Time (or the tracker), look at "Reminders to send today", copy, send, tick. That's the whole system.

Rule 1 · Payment terms to agree before any work

- [ ] **Deposit up front:** 30–50% before you start (100% for small jobs or new clients).
- [ ] **Due date in days:** "payment due within 14 days of invoice". Shorter terms get paid faster.
- [ ] **Late fee:** a fixed fee or a percentage per month. Check what's allowed where you and your client are.
- [ ] **Ownership on full payment:** final files and usage rights transfer only when paid in full.
- [ ] **Right to pause:** you can stop work if an invoice is more than X days overdue.

Copy-paste clause for your proposal, contract or first email:

> A [50]% deposit is due before work begins. The balance is due within [14] days of the invoice date. Invoices unpaid after the due date incur a late fee of [2% per month / a fixed fee of X]. Ownership of final deliverables transfers to the client once payment is received in full. [Your name] may pause work on any project while an invoice is more than [14] days overdue.

This is a practical template, not legal advice. Late-fee rules differ by country and state, so check yours or ask a local professional for anything large.

RULE 2

The invoice checklist

Every missing item is an excuse to pay later. Run through this before you hit send.

- [ ] A unique invoice number (INV-001, INV-002 …)
- [ ] The **due date written as a date** ("Due 16 November 2026"), not just "Net 14"
- [ ] Sent to the person who **pays**, with the person who hired you in CC
- [ ] The client's PO or reference number, if they use one (big companies often won't pay without it)
- [ ] What you did, in their words, with the date it was delivered
- [ ] Every way to pay you: bank details, PayPal, Wise, payment link
- [ ] Your late-fee line, matching the terms you agreed
- [ ] Sent the same day you deliver. Every day you wait is a day added to when you get paid.
- [ ] Logged in Paid On Time or the tracker the moment it's sent

RULE 3

The reminder ladder

Six steps, each a little firmer than the last. Because you send them on the calendar and not on your mood, you never sound angry, and the client always knows where they stand.

3 days before due	On the due date	3 days late	7 days late	14 days late	30 days late
Heads-up	**Due today**	**Friendly nudge**	**Firm reminder**	**Final notice**	**Pause work**
Warm	Neutral	Assume it slipped	Clear deadline	Consequence	Stop and escalate

If the client replies with a date, stop the ladder and note the date. If that date passes, jump to the next step. The app does this for you: it always picks the next unsent step for each invoice.

THE SCRIPTS

Copy, paste, get paid

The app fills these in automatically. To use them by hand, replace the [brackets].

1 · Heads-up — 3 days before due · Warm

Subject: Invoice [#] due [due date]

Hi [Name],

A quick heads-up that invoice [#] for [project] ([amount]) is due on [due date].

Thanks again, I really enjoyed working on this with you. Let me know if you need anything from me to process it.

Payment details:
[How to pay you]

Best,

[Your name]

WhatsApp / DM version
Hi [Name]! Quick heads-up: invoice [#] ([amount]) is due on [due date]. Let me know if you need anything to process it. Thanks!

2 · Due today — On the due date · Neutral

Subject: Invoice [#] is due today

Hi [Name],

Just a reminder that invoice [#] for [amount] is due today, [due date].

If it's already on its way, thank you, and please ignore this.

Payment details:
[How to pay you]

Best,

[Your name]

WhatsApp / DM version
Hi [Name], invoice [#] ([amount]) is due today. If it's already sent, thank you and please ignore this!

3 · Friendly nudge

3 days late · Assume it slipped

Subject: Friendly reminder: invoice [#] ([amount])

Hi [Name],

I hope you're well. I haven't seen payment for invoice [#] ([amount], due [due date]) come through yet, so I wanted to check it hasn't slipped through the cracks.

Could you let me know when it's scheduled? I've attached the invoice again in case it's useful.

Payment details:
[How to pay you]

Thanks,

[Your name]

WhatsApp / DM version
Hi [Name], hope you're well! I haven't received payment for invoice [#] ([amount], due [due date]) yet. Could you check when it's scheduled? Happy to resend the invoice.

4 · Firm reminder

7 days late · Clear deadline

Subject: Invoice [#] is now [X] days overdue

Hi [Name],

Invoice [#] for [amount] was due on [due date] and is now [X] days overdue.

Please arrange payment, or reply with the date it will be paid, by [date 3 days from now]. If there's a problem with the invoice or the work, tell me and I'll sort it out quickly.

Payment details:
[How to pay you]

Thank you,

[Your name]

WhatsApp / DM version
Hi [Name], invoice [#] ([amount]) is now [X] days overdue. Could you pay it, or tell me the payment date, by [date]? If there's an issue with it, let me know and I'll fix it.

5 · Final notice

14 days late · Consequence

Subject: Final reminder: invoice [#] ([amount])

Hi [Name],

This is a final reminder that invoice [#] for [amount], due on [due date], is still unpaid [X] days later.

As set out in our agreed terms, a late fee of [late fee] now applies. Please make payment by [date 3 days from now]. If I don't hear back by then I'll need to look at next steps, which I'd much rather avoid.

Payment details:
[How to pay you]

Regards,

[Your name]

WhatsApp / DM version

Hi [Name], final reminder: invoice [#] ([amount]) is [X] days overdue. Per our terms a late fee of [late fee] now applies. Please pay by [date], or I'll need to look at next steps.

6 · Pause work

30 days late · Stop and escalate

Subject: Invoice [#]: work paused until payment

Hi [Name],

Invoice [#] for [amount] is now [X] days overdue, and I haven't been able to get a payment date.

I'm pausing any further work and deliverables until the balance is settled. If it's not paid by [date], I'll move to formal recovery.

I'd still like to resolve this directly. If you can't pay in full, reply and propose a payment plan and I'll consider it.

Payment details:
[How to pay you]

Regards,

[Your name]

WhatsApp / DM version
Hi [Name], invoice [#] ([amount]) is now [X] days overdue. I'm pausing further work until it's settled. If it's not paid by [date] I'll move to formal recovery. If you need a payment plan, reply and we can agree one.

TOUGH SITUATIONS

When clients make excuses

"We're waiting to get paid by our client."	"I understand. Our agreement is between us, though, and the invoice was due on [date]. Can you confirm a date you'll pay this week, or would a split payment help?"
"It's with accounts."	"Thanks! Could you share the name or email of the person in accounts? I'll send it straight to them so it doesn't hold you up." Then send it to them directly.
"Cash is tight right now."	Offer a payment plan in writing: "Happy to split it: [half] by [date] and the rest by [date]. Can you confirm?" A plan with dates beats an open promise.
Silence (no replies at all)	Change channel. If you've emailed, send a WhatsApp or call. Then try someone else at the company. People ignore email more than they ignore a phone call.
"We're not happy with the work."	Ask for specifics in writing straight away. Fix genuine issues fast. Point out that the work was approved on [date] if it was. Don't let a vague complaint quietly cancel the whole invoice.
They want more work while unpaid	"Happy to start as soon as invoice [#] is settled." Never start new work for a client who already owes you.

After 30+ days

Stop all work, send the "Pause work" script, then decide whether the amount is worth formal recovery. Options include a formal letter of demand, a small-claims court, a collections agency, or the dispute process on the platform you were paid through. The rules differ by country, so look up your local process.

USING THE KIT

Quick start

The app (Paid-On-Time-App.html)

- [ ] Double-click to open it in Chrome, Edge, Safari or Firefox. No account, no internet needed, nothing to install.
- [ ] Settings: add your name, currency, late fee and how clients pay you. These go into every reminder.
- [ ] "+ New invoice" every time you send one. The "Today" screen shows what to send and fills in the message.
- [ ] Your data stays in this browser on this device. Use **Export backup** weekly, and **Import** to move it to another device.

The spreadsheet (Paid-On-Time-Tracker.xlsx)

- [ ] Works in Excel, Google Sheets (File → Import) and Numbers. Delete the 3 example rows first.
- [ ] Fill in the white columns. "Status" and "Send this reminder" work themselves out. The scripts are on the last tab.